Graphic Design

Corporate Identity

Summary Notes

Contents

4 Lesson outcomes

3 Introduction

4 What is corporate identity

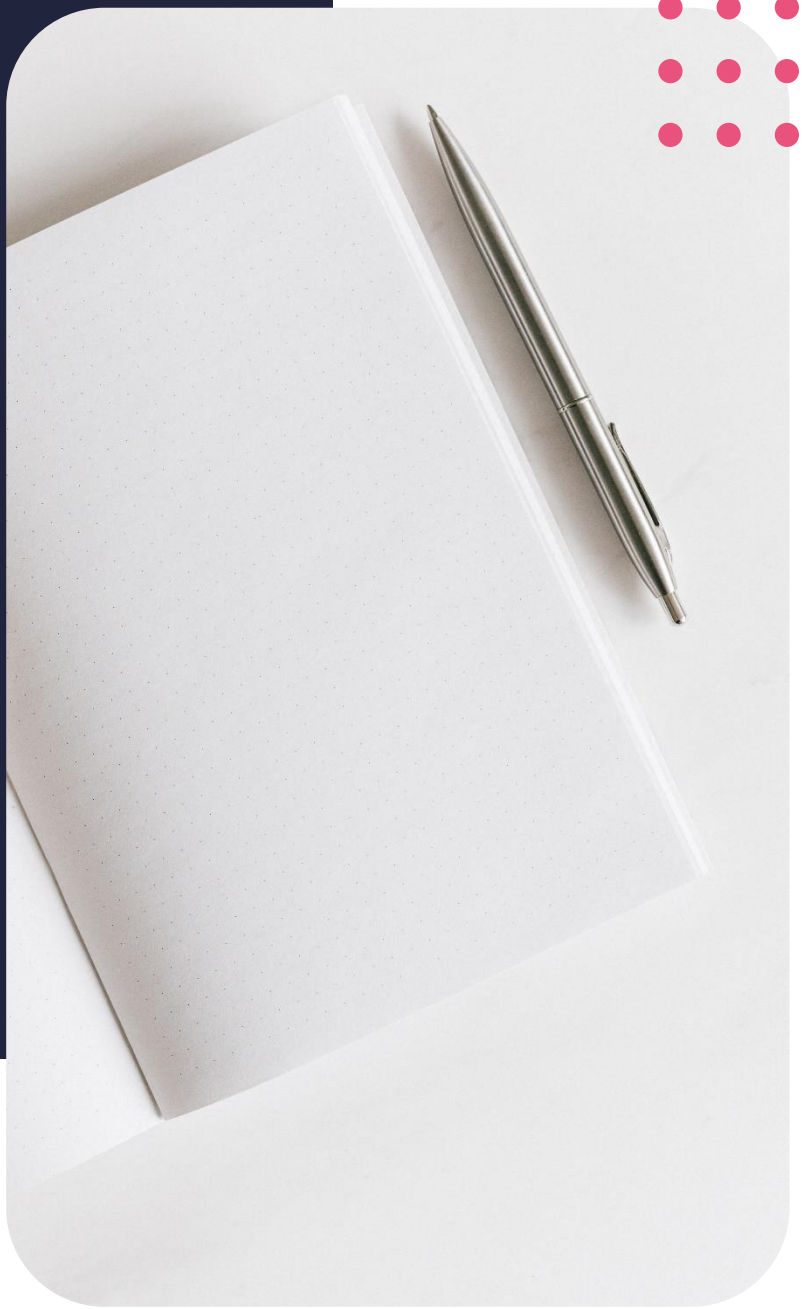
4 Creating a corporate identity

4 Principles of effective logo design

8 Demo: creating a corporate identity

10 Conclusion

11 References



Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Lesson outcome 1: What is a corporate identity
- Lesson outcome 2: Creating a corporate identity
- Lesson outcome 3: Principles of effective logo design
- Lesson outcome 4: Demo: Creating a corporate identity

Introduction

Our focus today will be on creating a corporate identity and specifically in creating an identity for yourself. You might be doing this course because you would like to become a professional graphic designer or simply because you have your own business and want to have the ability to design your own artwork. Either way, this is a valuable lesson irrespective of the reason why you are doing this course, as graphic designers are faced with corporate identities almost daily.

We all know the Wikipedia logo, but have you ever considered what it resembles?

Firstly, it resembles a globe constructed of puzzle pieces. Then there are different languages depicted on each of the puzzle pieces linking to Wikipedia's multilingualism.

These glyphs or letters mostly resemble the first glyph of the word Wikipedia in that specific language.

But have you noticed the missing puzzle piece in the top left of the logo? It is a symbol that information is always advancing and changing, thus, there will always be space for more information.

Since our lesson is about identity today, I would like to share the following quote by German psychologist, Erik Erikson with you. "In the social jungle of human existence, there is no feeling of being alive without a sense of identity." The same principle can be applied to identity in graphic design. Thus, you must first discover your design task's identity before it can truly communicate effectively. Understanding your brand's identity, will give its design that unique touch as well.

What is a corporate identity?

A corporate identity can be defined as the visual representation of a brand or company. In other words, how the brand or company presents itself to the public.

A corporate identity encapsulates the personality, qualities and culture of the business

in a consistent manner ensuring that the brand will be recognisable and remembered for this exact same reason.

A corporate identity consists of all the visual aspects of the brand or company; from the company logo, stationery like pens and letterheads, printed documents, website design, email signature, display advertising, packaging, employee uniforms, vehicle branding and basically anything that is visual either in print format or digitally.

Understanding that a corporate identity is applying the same style to all elements within a brand or company, we will look at how we can apply these principles to our corporate identity we will be creating today.

Creating a corporate identity

Our task today entails the creation of a corporate identity for yourself, your own personal identity. Whether you are wanting to start up a graphic design company or whether you would like new branding for your current business. Perhaps you're a hairdresser or an accountant looking for a company makeover. Irrespective of the business you choose to create a corporate identity, the principles remain the same.

I would like you to apply the process of creative thinking to come up with a clever logo concept. The brainstorming part will take longer than the actual creation of the logo, so don't stress too much on that – good ideas take time.

After we have created a logo, we will then move over to create a business card, letterhead, email signature and add your branding onto any other item – this can be a shirt, cap, pen or container.

Principles of effective logo design

The most difficult part of this project will probably be coming up with a clever logo concept as this is the starting point. There is a saying that goes: "a designer's worst nightmare is a blank page" and for a long time, this was a principle I applied to my design career until I realised that the blank page actually offers so many opportunities. The more I designed logos, the better I got at it. So, at first, this will seem like a daunting task, and believe me, even though I might be better at it, I am still not able to come up with a clever idea or logo concept quickly. This is the part that will take the longest and you will probably stare at the blank paper for ages. My advice; simply jot down the first ideas and concepts that come to mind. They will be cliché but at least it's a starting point. From there, let your ideas evolve into your own unique concepts.

So, what are the principles of effective logo design? There are simply rules or "Tick boxes" you want to tick when you have designed your logo. Always ask yourself whether your logo applied these principles successfully and if not, go back to the drawing board.

Simplicity

The first principle is to keep your logo simple. Always ask yourself this question when designing a logo: what can I still take away without jeopardising the connotation behind the logo or any design for that matter?

What is your initial thought on this logo example? It's quite trendy and modern right? It certainly looks professional but is it simple enough? What can we take away from this logo to still convey the correct message? This design might work well for other purposes but as a logo, it is just too busy.

Simplifying it, kept the main concept and simply round it off. The second example have an icon and word mark and can thus be used interchangeably.

Memorable

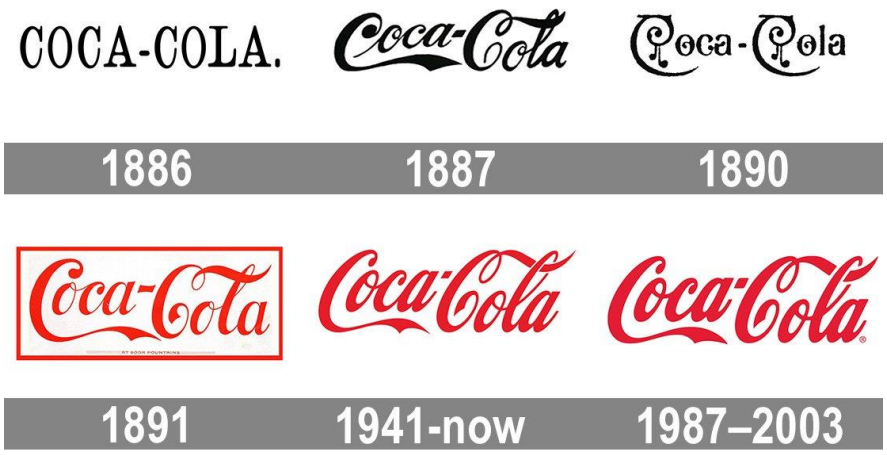
Next, make sure that your logo is memorable. Now, this is where it gets tricky, because how do you create something simple that is also memorable? With lots of research and brainstorming of course! Remember, if it is the first concept that you think of, it will probably be the first concept most people will think of, so spend time in your brainstorming phase to truly come up with a unique and memorable concept and apply the creative thinking techniques you learnt in our previous lesson, including the process on avoiding coming up with a cliché concept.

Avoid default fonts on your computer and rather download fonts. Just remember that if you would like more uniqueness and authenticity to your designs, you will most probably pay for a typeface and even adjust it to make it even more authentic. Especially when you use it for logo designing. But just don't use the default typefaces that came with your computer in a logo – EVER! There's nothing special to them and they won't make your logo special and memorable either. The same rule applies for basic designs and shapes.

Timeless

Be very careful, because what might seem amazing now, might only be so because it is very trendy. How do you determine whether your logo is timeless or not? By doing research. Dig into some history and specifically design history and determine the design styles that took place during the ages.

Rest assured that the simpler your logo is, the more timeless it will be. Also note that some logos slightly change with the times, so make sure that your logo has room for small adaptations if needed in future.



The Coca-Cola logo was merely a handwritten typeface back in the day and was thus used as such.

Versatility

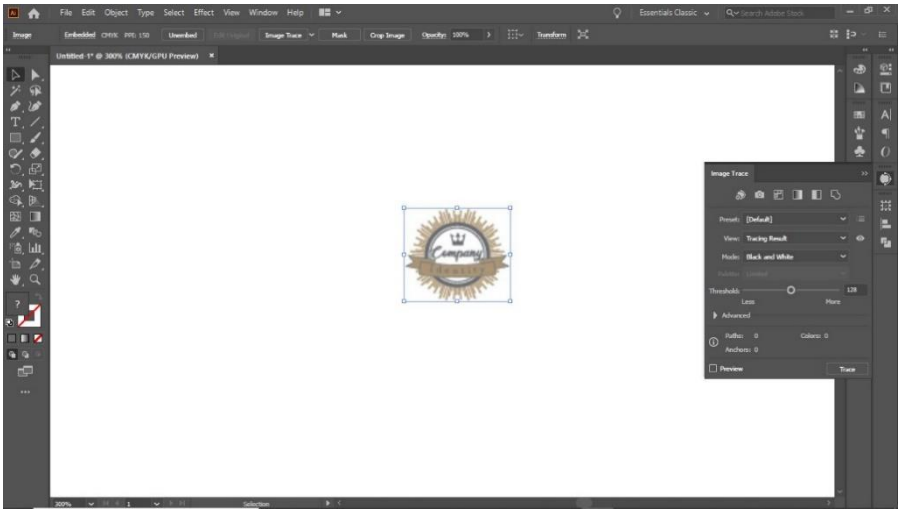
Versatility of a logo refers to whether your logo can work across a variety of media and applications. Therefore, it is important to design your logo in a vector editing software like Illustrator or CorelDraw as your logo will not lose quality if it is in vector format, meaning you can resize it inevitably. Your logo should also be versatile when it comes to size. Thus, it should be visible when printed on a ball point pen for example but also on a large billboard. If your logo loses too much detail when printed small, it is a sign that your logo has too much detail. The last aspect to consider here is to convert your logo to black and white. If your logo does not have detail when converted to black and white, you will need to reconsider your design.

The first logo we looked at seemed quite authentic and simple at first, but if resized, does it still convey the message accurately?

The rule of thumb is when designing a logo, always ask yourself whether it is visible when printed as big as your thumbnail or as large as a building.

Also, if you ever receive a logo from a client that you need to make use of in either a word document or in raster format, ask them to rather get the vector file.

If they can't provide you with the vector file, you will need to digitally retract the logo in vector format, thus increasing the time spent on the project. Inform them of this and charge them an additional fee for retracing the logo. I will show you a quick way to do this in Illustrator but it is unfortunately not always accurate, so make sure that you add enough time to redraw it manually.



(See lesson recording for Image Trace process)

Appropriate

Lastly, when speaking about the appropriateness of a logo, you need to make sure that the design style and typeface used conveys the correct message. Since logos are visuals and visuals are quicker to identify than reading, it would make sense for your logo to not misinform its audience.

The first example does not convey a formal, classical sense that is synonymous with a law firm. The typeface used seems too informal and playful and you might not take the brand or company seriously.

The second example immediately resonates with its audience by using symbolic meaning to convey the message and values of the company.

An effective logo should thus be very simple, but still be unique and memorable. You should be able to convert it to black and white and it needs to be distinctive and practical. Hence, you should be able to print at it at any size.

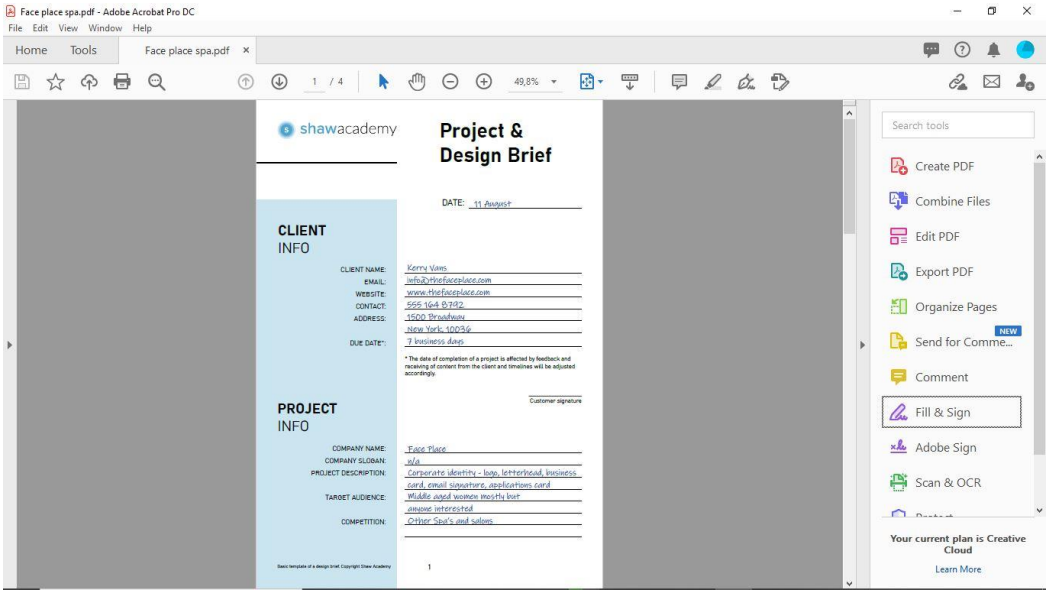
Take heart in what Paul Rand has to say about designing a logo:

- A logo does not sell, it identifies.
- A logo derives its meaning from the quality of the thing it symbolises, not the other way around.
- A logo is less important than the product it signifies; what it means is more important than what it looks like.

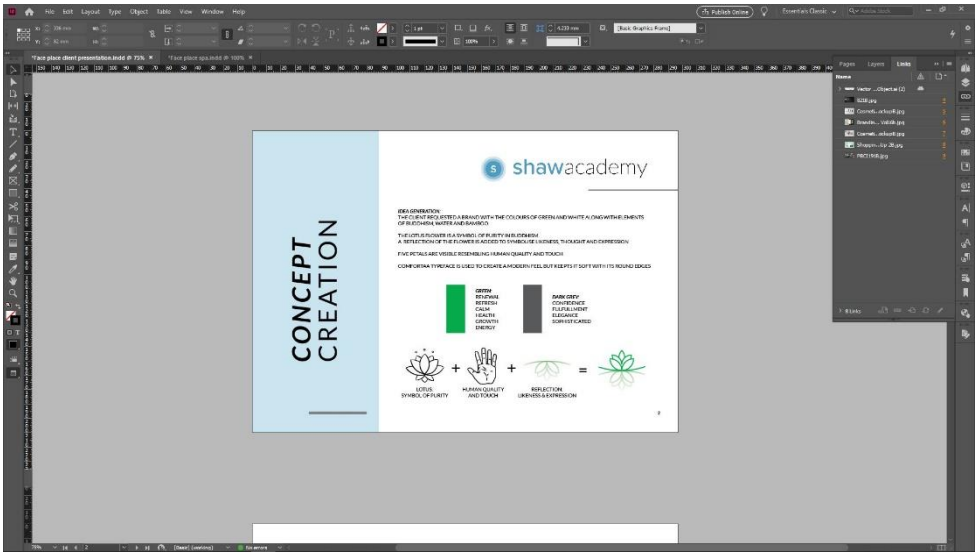
Essentially you want to combine your company or brand's values into one very simple icon or wording that will eventually resemble your company.

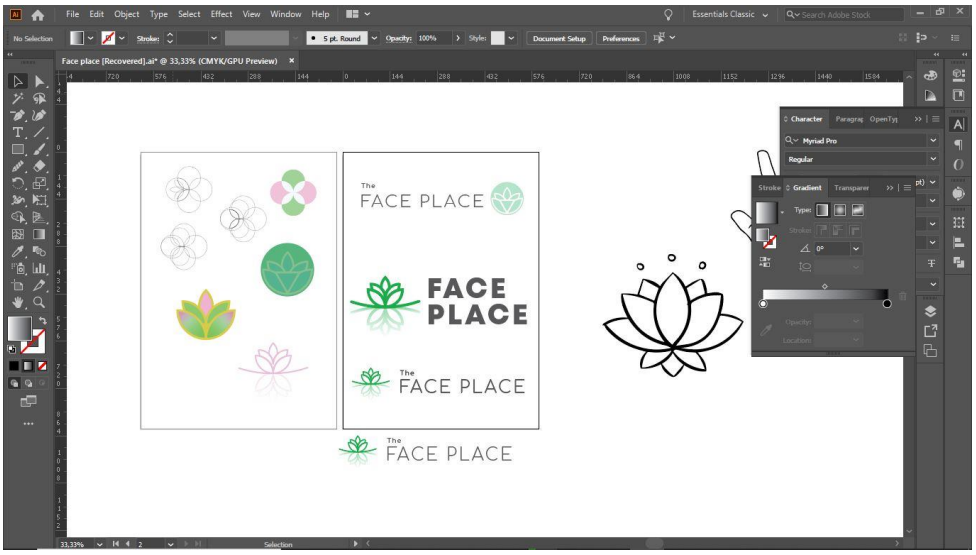
Demo: Creating a corporate identity

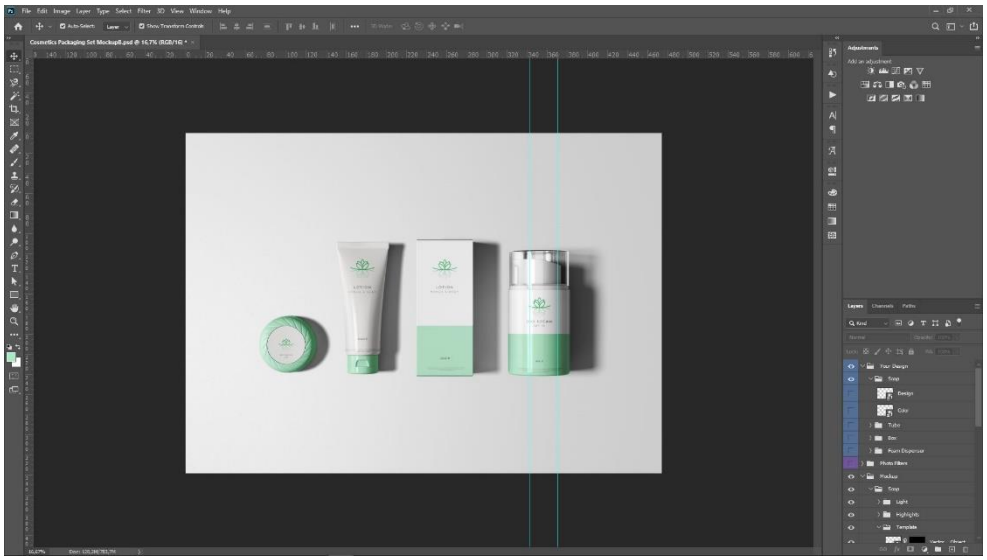
Understanding the basics of a corporate identity, takes time and practice. I have created a scenario where we will take the design process from beginning till end. I chose a spa as the business I will be creating a corporate identity for but you can apply the steps to come up with your own corporate identity, irrespective of the business you are creating it for. The most difficult part will most probably be the concept creation and idea generation and that is why it is crucial to interview your client thoroughly.



(See lesson recording for corporate identity process)







Conclusion

Whether you are creating a corporate identity for your own company or a client, the process does not really change. As we discovered, the idea generation and concept creation stage take the most time but if executed successfully, your identity will be effective and assist in the professional look and feel of the company.

Share your corporate identity on your favourite social media platform

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